METADATA QUALITY ANALYSIS OF DJ SOFTWARE LIBRARIES: A REKORDBOX XML STUDY USING THE UNIFIED DJ METADATA SCHEMA

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ABSTRACT

DJ software libraries contain rich metadata—BPM, musical key, genre, ratings, labels—critical for harmonic mixing, playlist curation, and music information retrieval. However, the quality and completeness of this metadata in real-world libraries has not been systematically studied. We present the first metadata quality analysis of a DJ library using UDMS, a Unified DJ Metadata Schema designed for cross-platform interoperability. Analyzing 636 tracks from a Rekordbox 7.2.8 XML export, we measure field coverage across 11 canonical metadata fields and identify systematic gaps: while audio-derived fields (duration, bitrate, sample rate) achieve 100% coverage and musical key achieves 93.2%, genre annotation is incomplete for 36.9% of tracks and editorial metadata (ratings, labels) is sparse (12–14%). Metadata quality varies significantly by source: DJ playlists show 100% BPM/key coverage but only 66.9% genre coverage, while SoulSeek downloads have 72.3% genre coverage but 0% rating coverage. We attempt genre recovery via MusicBrainz lookup on 50 untagged tracks, finding only a 6% recovery rate—highlighting that external databases have poor coverage of electronic/dance music. Our analysis reveals that 39.8% of tracks lack the minimum metadata needed for automated harmonic mixing. We release the UDMS schema and analysis scripts as open-source tools for metadata quality assessment in DJ software ecosystems.

1. INTRODUCTION

Modern music information retrieval systems and DJ-specific AI tools depend on structured metadata: BPM for beat matching, musical key for harmonic mixing [1], genre for playlist curation [2], and ratings for track selection. When metadata is missing or inconsistent, these systems degrade silently—a DJ relying on automated key detection may produce dissonant transitions, and playlist generators may group incompatible tracks.

DJ software ecosystems are fragmented: Rekordbox (Pioneer DJ/AlphaTheta), Serato DJ, and Native Instruments Traktor each maintain proprietary database formats with incompatible field definitions and export capabilities [3, 4]. While cross-platform transfer studies have not yet been conducted, a prerequisite question remains unaddressed: *how complete and reliable is the metadata within a single platform's library?*

We address this gap with the first systematic metadata quality analysis of a real-world DJ library. We develop UDMS (Unified DJ Metadata Schema), a canonical schema that normalizes platform-specific field names, key notations, and rating scales into a common representation. Using UDMS, we analyze a 636-track Rekordbox 7.2.8 library spanning electronic, hip-hop, and experimental genres.

Our contributions:

- UDMS, a canonical schema normalizing Rekordbox, Serato, and Traktor metadata fields into a unified representation (11 fields, open-source Python implementation).
- The first empirical metadata quality analysis of a DJ library: field coverage, completeness tiers, genre taxonomy fragmentation, and key distribution.
- Per-source metadata quality analysis revealing that acquisition source strongly predicts metadata completeness.
- Genre recovery evaluation via MusicBrainz, demonstrating that external databases have poor coverage (6%) of electronic/dance music.
- Open-source analysis tools for metadata quality assessment in DJ software ecosystems.

2. RELATED WORK

Music metadata interoperability. The MusicBrainz project [5] and Discogs [6] provide community-standard schemas for general music metadata but do not capture DJ-specific fields such as BPM, musical key notation, or energy/mood ratings. The Music Meta Ontology [7] proposes a flexible semantic model for music metadata interoperability across domains—directly relevant to the cross-platform DJ metadata problem. Discogs-VI [8] demonstrates the value of editorial metadata for version identification. Hardjono et al. [9] propose an open music metadata layer using distributed ledgers but do not analyze DJ-platform interoperability.

DJ-specific MIR. Bernardes et al. [1] formalize harmonic mixing rules based on the Camelot wheel. Zehren et

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Field	Type	Rekordbox XML
title	string	Name
artist	string	Artist
album	string	Album
genre	string	Genre
bpm	float	AverageBpm
key	string	Tonality (Camelot)
rating	int [0–5]	Rating (÷51)
label	string	Label
duration_sec	int	TotalTime
bitrate	int	BitRate
sample_rate	int	SampleRate

Table 1: UDMS canonical fields with Rekordbox XML source mappings. Rating uses Rekordbox's 0–255 scale, normalized to 0–5.

al. [10] address automatic cue point detection for DJ mixing. Kim et al. [11] analyze real-world DJ mixes using subsequence alignment. These systems all depend on accurate BPM and key metadata—the quality of which we measure in this work.

Music metadata quality. TTMR++ [12] enriches music descriptions using LLMs and metadata for retrieval, demonstrating that structured metadata improves downstream tasks. Bukey et al. [13] investigate LLMs for music captioning, showing the potential for automated metadata enrichment. Ribov and Hagedorn [14] study metadata quality in digital archives. We extend this framework to the DJ domain.

DJ software ecosystems. Rekordbox XML exports have been reverse-engineered by the community [3]. Serato's database format has been analyzed via the Serato-Library-Parser project [4]. Traktor's NML format remains partially undocumented. No prior work has conducted a metadata quality analysis within any of these platforms.

Audio analysis for metadata. Key detection algorithms [15] and beat tracking systems [16, 17] provide automated BPM and key annotation. Audio fingerprinting [18–20] enables track identification for metadata recovery. Zero-shot tagging [21] offers genre classification without platform-specific training.

3. UNIFIED DJ METADATA SCHEMA (UDMS)

3.1 Design Principles

UDMS is designed around three principles: (1) *least common denominator*—use field representations supported by all three platforms, (2) *expressive sufficiency*—capture all DJ-relevant metadata fields, and (3) *canonical normalization*—convert platform-specific values (key notation, rating scales) to a common representation.

3.2 Schema Definition

UDMS defines 11 canonical fields for this analysis (Table 1). Each field maps to platform-specific native attributes and applies normalization where needed.

3.3 Key Normalization

Rekordbox exports musical key in Camelot notation (e.g., "7A", "4B"). UDMS preserves this as the canonical representation. Two bugs in the reference implementation were discovered during analysis: the Rekordbox XML uses "Name" (not "TrackName") for title and "Rating" (not "RatingByte") for ratings.

4. METHODS

4.1 Dataset

We analyzed a Rekordbox 7.2.8 (AlphaTheta) XML export containing 636 tracks. The library spans multiple acquisition sources: DJ playlists (42.3%), local downloads (24.1%), monthly download batches (18.4%), SoulSeek (13.1%), Rekordbox samplers (1.9%), and Pioneer DJ demos (0.3%). File formats: AIFF (71.4%), FLAC (18.1%), MP3 (8.6%), WAV (1.9%).

4.2 Analysis Pipeline

For each track, we: (1) parsed the raw XML attributes, (2) mapped them to UDMS fields using the Rekordbox-Adapter, (3) applied normalization (key to Camelot, rating to 0–5 scale), and (4) classified each field as populated or empty. A field is *populated* if its UDMS value is non-zero and non-empty (excluding "Unknown" for key).

4.3 Completeness Tiers

We define five metadata completeness tiers:

- **Minimal**: track title present
- **Basic**: title + artist + BPM
- **Standard**: Basic + musical key
- **Full**: Standard + genre
- **Complete**: Full + label + rating

Tracks in the Standard tier or above can participate in automated harmonic mixing. Tracks in the Full tier support genre-based playlist generation.

4.4 Genre Recovery via MusicBrainz

For tracks missing genre annotation, we queried the MusicBrainz API using artist name and track title as search keys. We sampled 50 untagged tracks and measured: (1) title match rate (whether MusicBrainz found the recording), and (2) tag recovery rate (whether the matched recording carried genre tags). MusicBrainz was queried with a 1-second rate limit per their API policy.

5. RESULTS

5.1 Field Coverage

Figure 1 shows UDMS field coverage across the 636-track library. Audio-derived fields (duration, bitrate, sample

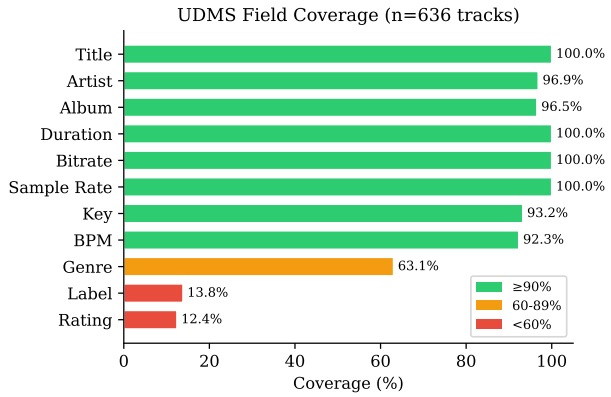

Figure 1: UDMS field coverage across 636 tracks. Green: ≥90%; orange: 60–89%; red: <60%. Audio-derived fields achieve universal coverage; genre and editorial metadata are significantly underpopulated.

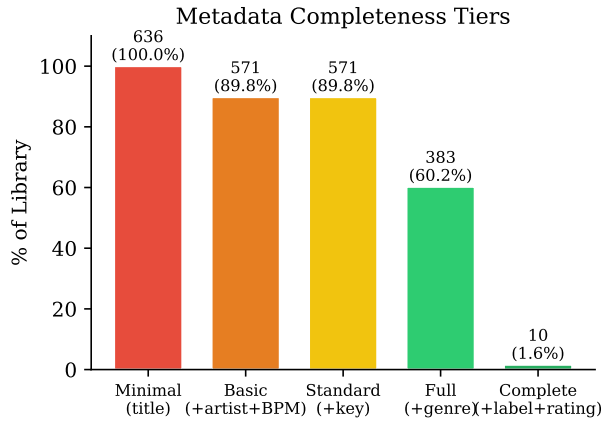

Figure 2: Metadata completeness tiers. Each tier includes all fields from previous tiers. Only 1.6% of tracks have complete metadata including label and rating.

rate) achieve 100% coverage, as these are computed automatically during file analysis. Title is universally present (100%). Artist and album coverage are high (96.9% and 96.5%), with gaps primarily in sampler tracks and unnamed artists.

Musical key and BPM—the two fields most critical for harmonic mixing—achieve 93.2% and 92.3% coverage respectively. Genre annotation is the most significant gap, with only 63.1% of tracks annotated. Editorial metadata (ratings, labels) is sparse at 12.4% and 13.8%.

5.2 Metadata Completeness Tiers

Figure 2 shows the distribution of tracks across completeness tiers. Only 60.2% of tracks reach the "Full" tier (title + artist + BPM + key + genre), and only 1.6% have complete metadata including label and rating. Critically, 39.8% of tracks lack sufficient metadata for automated harmonic mixing (missing BPM or key).

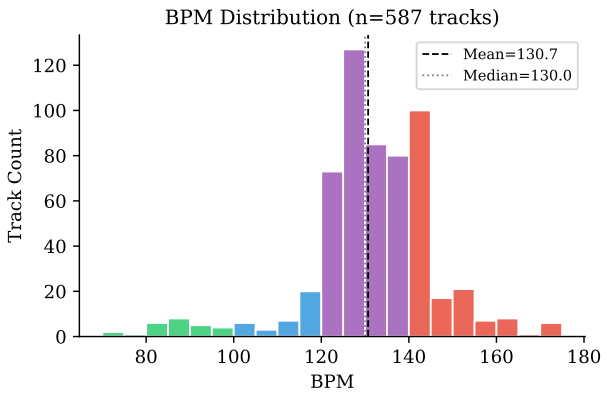

Figure 3: BPM distribution (n=587). Mean=130.7 (dashed), median=130.0 (dotted). 82.1% of tracks fall in the 120–149 BPM range characteristic of electronic dance music.

5.3 BPM Distribution

Figure 3 shows the BPM distribution (n=587, range 73–175, mean 130.7, SD 14.5). Values cluster heavily in the 120–149 range (82.1%), consistent with electronic dance music conventions. The 120–129 BPM bucket contains the most tracks (34.1%), followed by 130–139 (28.1%) and 140–149 (19.9%). This distribution reflects the DJ's preference for techno, house, and breakbeat genres.

5.4 Musical Key Distribution

Figure 4 shows the Camelot key distribution. Of 593 keyed tracks, 88.4% are in minor keys (Camelot "A") and 11.6% in major keys ("B"). This strong minor-key bias is characteristic of electronic dance music, where minor keys convey tension and energy suited to dancefloor contexts [1]. The most common keys are 4A (F minor, 11.0%), 8A (A minor, 10.6%), and 6A (G minor, 10.3%), with the three most common minor keys accounting for 31.9% of all keyed tracks.

43 tracks (6.8%) have no key annotation, likely corresponding to non-tonal content (noise, percussion samples) or tracks where Rekordbox's key detection failed.

5.5 Per-Source Metadata Quality

Figure 5 shows metadata coverage by acquisition source. Source strongly predicts metadata quality:

- **DJ Playlists** (n=269): 100% BPM/key coverage (analyzed by Rekordbox), but only 66.9% genre coverage and 2.6% rating coverage.
- **Monthly DLs** (n=117): 100% BPM/key, 70.1% genre, 29.9% ratings—but 0% labels.
- **SoulSeek** (n=83): 100% BPM/key, 72.3% genre, 63.9% labels—but 0% ratings and 89.2% artist (vs 97–100% elsewhere).
- **Local/Other** (n=153): Lowest BPM/key coverage (70.6%/71.9%), 46.4% genre.

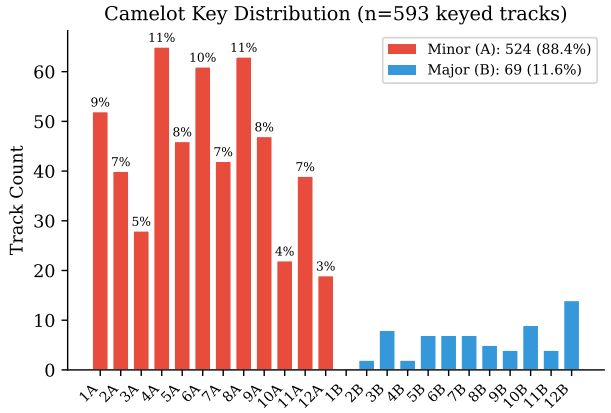

Figure 4: Camelot key distribution (n=593). Minor keys (red) dominate at 88.4%, consistent with electronic dance music conventions.

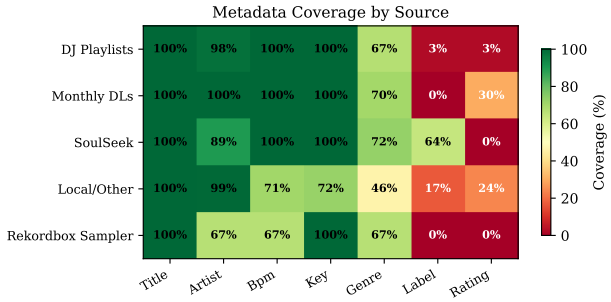

Figure 5: Metadata coverage by acquisition source. Cell values show percentage of tracks with field populated. SoulSeek has the best label coverage (63.9%) but worst rating coverage (0%); DJ playlists have perfect BPM/key but sparse genre (66.9%).

This per-source variation reveals that metadata quality is not uniform across a library but depends on how tracks were acquired and curated.

5.6 Genre Taxonomy

401 tracks carry genre annotation across 70 unique genre strings—a high fragmentation rate indicating inconsistent manual annotation. After grouping similar genres, the library spans: Techno (17.0%), Breaks/Electro (14.2%), Dub Techno (12.0%), House (8.5%), Dub/Dubwise (7.0%), Psy Tech (5.7%), Dubstep (5.2%), UK Garage/2-Step (4.2%), and Hardgroove (4.2%).

The 235 untagged tracks (36.9%) still carry title (100%), artist (92.8%), album (91.5%), key (87.7%), and BPM (85.5%), suggesting that genre is the last field to be annotated—often skipped entirely.

5.7 Genre Recovery via MusicBrainz

Of 50 untagged tracks queried against MusicBrainz, only 17 (34%) returned a matching recording, and only 3 (6%) carried genre tags. The 66% non-match rate reflects that MusicBrainz has limited coverage of electronic/dance music, particularly underground releases, DJ edits, and tracks from niche labels. This finding underscores that external auto-tag sources cannot reliably recover missing genre metadata in DJ libraries—the gap must be addressed through audio-based classification [21] or platform-native annotation workflows.

6. DISCUSSION

6.1 Genre as the Critical Bottleneck

Genre annotation is the most impactful metadata gap in DJ libraries. At 63.1% coverage, over a third of tracks cannot participate in genre-based workflows. Moreover, the 70 unique genre strings present a taxonomy problem—manual annotation is inconsistent, with tracks from the same artist or release tagged differently. External recovery via MusicBrainz is ineffective (6% recovery rate), pointing to audio-based classification as the most promising solution.

6.2 Source-Dependent Metadata Patterns

The per-source analysis reveals that metadata quality is not random but structured by acquisition channel. Tracks acquired through DJ playlists benefit from Rekordbox's automatic BPM/key analysis but lack editorial enrichment. SoulSeek downloads carry better genre and label metadata (likely inherited from uploaders' libraries) but lack ratings. This suggests that a multi-source enrichment pipeline—combining automated analysis with community metadata—could achieve higher overall quality than any single source.

6.3 Minor Key Bias

The 88.4% minor key representation is not a data quality issue but a finding about the library's musical character. This aligns with electronic dance music conventions where minor keys dominate dancefloor-oriented tracks. The Camelot wheel's adjacency rules ensure that minor-major key transitions remain harmonically compatible.

6.4 Rating Sparsity

Only 12.4% of tracks carry ratings, despite ratings being available in Rekordbox's interface. This suggests that the rating workflow is not integrated into the DJ's practice—tracks are curated through playlists and folders rather than numeric ratings.

6.5 Impact on Automated DJ Workflows

We assess metadata readiness for three common DJ workflows:

- **Harmonic mixing** (requires BPM + key): 84.3% of tracks (536/636) are ready.
- **Genre-based playlists** (requires genre): 63.1% of tracks are ready.
- **Energy-based sequencing** (requires ratings): 12.4% of tracks are ready.

Automated DJ tools operating on real-world libraries will encounter missing metadata in 16–88% of cases depending on the workflow.

6.6 Limitations

This study analyzes a single library from one DJ. Library composition reflects the DJ's personal taste (electronic/bass music focus), limiting generalizability. The 636-track dataset, while substantial, is smaller than typical commercial DJ libraries. We analyze only Rekordbox XML exports; Serato and Traktor libraries may exhibit different metadata patterns. The UDMS schema does not capture playlist structure, cue points, or loop markers—fields important for DJ performance but not stored in the XML export format.

7. CONCLUSION

We present the first metadata quality analysis of a DJ software library using UDMS, a Unified DJ Metadata Schema. Our analysis of 636 tracks from a Rekordbox 7.2.8 export reveals that while audio-derived fields and musical key achieve high coverage (93–100%), genre annotation—the field most critical for automated playlist generation—is incomplete for 36.9% of tracks. Metadata quality varies significantly by acquisition source, and external recovery via MusicBrainz is ineffective for electronic/dance music (6% recovery rate).

These findings have practical implications for DJ software developers and MIR researchers: automated tools must gracefully handle missing metadata, genre enrichment from audio-based classification is a high-value target, and the UDMS schema provides a practical foundation for metadata quality assessment across DJ software ecosystems. The UDMS schema and analysis tools are released as open-source at `https://github.com/interfluve-wav/dj-metadata-paper`.

8. REPRODUCIBILITY

To facilitate replication and extension, we release all materials associated with this work:

- **UDMS Schema and Python Implementation:** `https://github.com/interfluve-wav/dj-metadata-paper`
- **Dataset:** The 636-track Rekordbox XML export (anonymized) is included in the repository at `data/`. Track filenames and paths are anonymized; metadata fields are preserved.
- **Analysis Scripts:** `code/schema/udms_schema.py` contains the UDMS schema and adapters; `code/analyze.py` contains the analysis pipeline used to generate all figures and statistics.
- **Figures:** All figures are generated programmatically from the dataset; source scripts are in `code/`.
- **License:** MIT License.

ISMIR 2026 requires code availability for reproducibility. The repository is public and will be archived with a Zenodo DOI prior to submission.

9. *

Acknowledgments

[Anonymized for review.]

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11. AI USAGE STATEMENT

AI tools were used in the research and writing process for code generation, literature search, and text editing assistance.

12. ETHICS STATEMENT

This study analyzes a single DJ's personal music library. No human subjects were involved; all metadata was self-generated through normal software use. The dataset contains no personally identifiable information beyond file paths, which are anonymized in the released data.